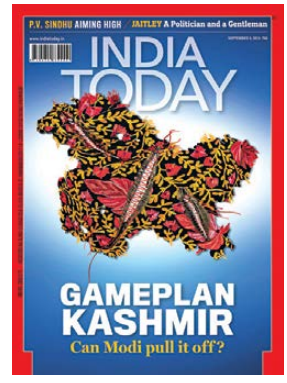
FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Jammu and Kashmir is turning a historic corner. Its people are voting for an assembly after a full 10 years. Even the rural interiors of the Valley are buzzing with door-to-door and street-corner campaigners. For the first time in 30 years, there's no boycott call. But it's not as if paradise has been regained and disquiet banished for good: the political soil is still stirring from the definitive changes seen in the last decade. In 2019, the Narendra Modi government annulled Article 370 and downgraded J&K to Union Territory status, hiving off Ladakh. Actions that would normally call for the state assembly's seal were done under President's rule. Happily, the debate is being taken to the ballot—amid mass participation. The first phase of voting, on September 18, saw an unprecedented turnout of 59 per cent, surpassing even the 58 per cent in the Lok Sabha election. What flows out of this mandate will carry the most sacred imprimatur in a democracy: the will of the people.



September 9, 2019

At the macro level, it is a fight for dominance between the BJP and the National Conference (NC), backed by its INDIA bloc ally Congress. The Peoples Democratic Party (PDP), perceived to have partly lost the plot, makes up a smaller side of the triangle. Delimitation has increased J&K's seats from 87 to 90, even without Ladakh—Jammu's share went up by six seats to 43; the Valley got one more to reach 47. The BJP has long dreamed of having its own chief minister in J&K. To be able to "form a government without the NC and the PDP", it has to win 30-35 seats in Jammu, then make up the numbers with allied parties/ Independents from Kashmir. To thwart that, the NC will need to mop up a majority of the Valley seats, with the Congress picking up enough in Jammu to keep the BJP out of shooting range.

Mustering up an outright majority of 46 seats won't be easy for either side. The BJP's overall vote share in the recent Lok Sabha election saw a steep decline from 46.7 per cent in 2019 to 24.4 per cent. It has been inducting new faces to compensate for a rare spurt of dissension—a former state vice-president is among those contesting as Independents. Still, of the 37 assembly seats in Jammu and Udhampur, the Lok Sabha vote gave it a lead in 29. The eight seats in the mountainous border districts of Rajouri and Poonch are a new focus point. The grant of tribal status to the Pahari community bolsters its chances. Domicile and hitherto-denied reservation benefits for Valmikis open up the seven SC-reserved seats. The BJP's primary narrative is nationalism. To that, it has added development: a slew of showpiece tunnels, bridges and expressways.

The NC's 22.3 per cent vote share in the Lok Sabha election gave it a lead in 34 assembly seats in Kashmir. But its problem is not just whether the Congress can pull its weight in Jammu: the national party got 19.4 per cent votes in summer but is struggling with desertions. As NC leader Omar Abdullah says, the BJP's strategy is to try and "fracture the mandate in the Valley while consolidating it in Jammu". Aiding this are a couple of so-called King's parties. Though distancing themselves to preclude any taint of association with the BJP, they may slice off votes. But there's another chess piece of striking novelty that can spoil the INDIA bloc's plans. A whole range of erstwhile separatists are in the fray for the first time. The controversial 'Engineer' Rashid had mounted a proxy campaign from Tihar jail for his stunning 472,481-vote win over Omar and Sajad Lone from Baramulla in the general election. Now he has been allowed interim bail to campaign for 34 candidates of his Awami Ittehad Party. The proscribed Jamaat-e-Islami, hitherto a staunch member of the Hurriyat Conference and routine supporter of election boycott calls, too, is making a proxy return to formal politics after decades. Its slew of Independents are a huge draw.

Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa and Group Photo Editor Bandeep Singh travelled extensively in Jammu and the Valley for this week's cover story, meeting a cross-section of leaders and observing rallies in the interiors. Voices from the full political spectrum—NC, PDP, BJP, Congress, former azadi sympathisers—are represented in a separate section. "This is the first step towards getting back what New Delhi took away from us." Those words from Apni Party chief Altaf Bukhari reflect the mood on the ground. Opinions on Article 370 and statehood continue to be supercharged. PDP chief Mehbooba Mufti, the last CM, says any resolution in Kashmir "will have to start from restoring 370". But Omar says he's "realistic enough to know...the battle to try and get it restored is not going to end tomorrow". Others talk of it as a federal solution. The BJP, dead set against "turning the clock back", is highlighting how the "fear psychosis" of old has disappeared and the terror graph is at historic lows.

Despite all these cross-currents, the fact that a wide spectrum of parties and Independents are participating in elections has to be heartily welcomed. Kashmir's future is being crafted, after all, via ballots, not bullets.

(Aroon Purie)